

tain the word “streaming”, as in streaming audio or streaming video. An increasing number of people are now able to watch video or listen to Internet radio. One such person is Anurag Bhateja, MD of Bhateja Computers in Chandigarh and a self-confessed Net freak. “I love funny Web sites and videos. I watch online trailers and read about the entertainment industry in my free time. I also love sites such as StumbleUpon.com.” He says he’s been inspired by the articles of Pawan Duggal, noted cybercrime lawyer: “I am totally against piracy and pornography, and am working on a site that will educate people about Internet crime.”

Another *Digit* reader (and another Anurag) is Anurag Patel, an IT Professional from Mumbai, who has an always-on connection. “I feel like my bandwidth is being wasted if I am not doing something with it. I recently upgraded my Ubuntu installation, which took almost two days. When I am not doing anything like that, I spend time on YouTube.com, or look for developer documentation. I also waste a lot of bandwidth downloading from RapidShare.de, from links that other *Digit* readers on Yahoo! Messenger keep providing—even though most of them are useless for me, because I’m on Linux.” For those of you who don’t know about it, RapidShare has become a popular place for people to share almost any sort of file with their friends.

Another popular way of using bandwidth is Internet radio, especially from within programs such as Yahoo! Messenger or Winamp. A *Digit* reader from Delhi, a college student who asked not to be named, uses Winamp for streaming video. “Since I have a computer that my sister and father also use, I cannot really use my broadband to download the things I want, because they might find it on the hard drive. Instead, I use Winamp’s Internet TV Library, which has everything from music videos to porn. I also visit adult sites that offer free streaming video.”

Downloading Software

Most of the people we spoke to were frequent visitors to sites such as ZDNetIndia.com, Download.com and Softpedia.com. And most of them didn’t even feel the need for software, and didn’t have any task they needed to accomplish—they just wanted to know what’s out there.

“I’ve downloaded about 30 GB of multimedia-related software in the past four months—just to try them out,” says Anurag Bhateja. And he’s not unique in any way: most people are doing exactly the same with their broadband pipes.



A 256 Kbps unlimited connection is fun. I got this connection four months ago and have already downloaded about 37 GB”

Anurag Bhateja
Chandigarh

“I didn’t even know there was software that could automatically sort my music collection for me until I saw the category on Download.com. I downloaded about five of them, tried them all, chose the best one and then promptly found a crack for it—an evening well spent online,” says the student from Delhi who was quoted earlier—rather cheekily, I might add!

Using World Mapping

Google Earth, Google Moon, and WikiMapia (www.wikimapia.com) seem to be the most popular choices for people who dabble in online mapping. A lot of the people I spoke to spend at least an hour a week on Google Earth and WikiMapia, adding places they know to the community Web. Though it’s absolutely pointless for most of us, it still seems fun for some people to put their homes on a world map!

Clogging The Pipes

As you can see, there are many different ways in which people use (read waste) bandwidth and time online. Some of these are actually good, because we can learn from them—and I don’t mean the porn!

From my little survey, which was only conducted with a little under a hundred people I know online or from the *Digit* Forum (<http://www.thinkdigit.com/forum>), I found that a lot of people do their downloading at work, where most people have broadband access. They then burn CDs/DVDs, or transfer the data to external hard drives or USB drives to take home. This may become cause for concern to employers, because a lot of people seem to be using company-provided bandwidth for some very illegal uses—but that’s another discussion for another time.

At least some people I spoke to seemed to have found constructive ways in which to utilise bandwidth, such as downloading and then learning how to use new software. A few even believe that bandwidth should be conserved...

I’ll leave you with a quote from a call centre manager in Mumbai: “Sure, I download pornography and warez, but only what I need and when I need it. I’m against this whole ‘leech every last Kbps you can’ thing. If everyone only used what they needed, there’d be more to go around, and bandwidth would be cheaper!”

“We save water, we don’t waste food, and we suffer in the heat to conserve energy—why can’t we conserve bandwidth the same way? After all, what’s more scarce in India than bandwidth?”

Now *that’s* food for thought!■

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